Prologue

Kisi ko ghar se nikalte hi mil gai manzil
Koi hamari tarah umr bhar safar mein raha

Some found their destiny at their doorstep.
Others like me were fated to be in the wilderness all their lives.

—Ahmed Faraz

The majestic but forlorn nineteenth-century building of Bradlaugh Hall, now derelict, sad and destitute, still stands behind the district courts of Lahore. Here, the National College, founded by Lala Lajpat Rai and practising the novelty of using books written in the English language, once schooled its 200 Hindu, Muslim and Sikh students. One such student was the nineteen-year-old Bhagat Singh, who established the Naujawan Bharat Sabha (Young Society of India) at Bradlaugh Hall in 1926. He was just coming to the end of his four-year tenure there, from 1922 to 1926. And the Sabha for him was to be the public face of the Hindustan Republican Association.

Bradlaugh Hall, however, has an illustrious past unknown to most Lahoris even today. If Bradlaugh Hall could speak, it would tell its own wistful story—a story of how in 1915 the Ghadar Party had its base here. With its enviable position in the heart of Lahore, Bradlaugh Hall had by the 1920s become the centre of political activity and had come to be known as such throughout India. From Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru to Quaid-e-Azam Muhammad Ali Jinnah and from Allama Muhammad Iqbal to Subhas Chandra Bose, all addressed their followers from Bradlaugh Hall. It was a bastion of art, literature and high culture. Cowasjee and Habib Seth, the two Parsi theatrical companies, both performed here. *Mushairas* and stage